Local SEO Masterclass

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Ranking a Local Google ...

Introduction to Local SEO

NAP Consistency + Map Emb...

Getting ONLY 5 Star Reviews f...

Getting a Google My Busines...

GMB Location + Direction Ma...

Rank and Rent (Organic S...

Introduction to Rank and Rents

Setting up a Rank and Rent

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Local SEO for Beginners (...

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Module 2: Setting Up Your Go...

Module 8: Building Citations

Overview: Citations are mentions of your business's NAP (Name, Address, Phone) on other websites, typically directory or listing sites like Yelp, Yellow Pages, Facebook, Apple Maps, etc. Citations are a foundational aspect of local SEO – they help verify the legitimacy and location of a business. In this module, you'll learn how to build and clean up citations step-by-step. We will identify the top directories to get listed on, show you how to ensure 100% consistency in how your business info appears, and cover tools or tactics to manage many listings efficiently. By actively managing citations, you'll strengthen the business's web presence, boosting Google's confidence in displaying it in local results.

Lessons:

1. **What are Citations and Why They Matter** – We define citations clearly: any online listing of your business's key details (NAP). Unlike backlinks, a citation might not always include a link to your site (it could just be a mention of the business info). Citations matter because Google cross-references this data to ensure your business is real and info is correct. We explain that having citations on **authoritative sites** (like well-known directories or industry-specific sites) is most valuable. A strong citation profile can improve local rankings, whereas inconsistent or incorrect citations can hurt (Google might get confused if different addresses or

citation websites: for example, Google Business Profile (done), Bing Places (done), **Yelp**, **Facebook Business Page**, **Apple Maps**, **YellowPages**, **Foursquare**, **Angi** (for home services), etc., as well as popular data aggregators (like Factual, Localeze, etc., which distribute to smaller sites). If

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relevant, we mention niche directories (e.g., Healthgrades for medical, TripAdvisor for hospitality, etc.). Students will learn to identify the important directories in their country/region (since it can vary – e.g., in the UK you'd consider Yell, in Canada, 411.ca, etc.).

3. **Consistency is Key** – We hammer home the rule: use the **exact same NAP everywhere**. This lesson might show an example of a consistency issue: "Street" vs "St." or using a tracking phone number on one site but main number on another – and why those can be problematic. We advise creating a master document of the business info *exactly* as it should appear, and copy-pasting from it to avoid typos or variations. Even minor differences like "Suite 5" vs "Ste 5" can create inconsistencies. Wherever possible, include the website URL on citations and a category matching your business type.

4. **Step-by-Step: Creating a Citation** – We walk through an example of claiming or adding a listing on a major site (say Yelp or Yelp's equivalent). Typically: search for the business on that site first (to avoid duplicate listings), if not found, click "Add business," fill out the profile (name, address, phone, website, hours, description), and submit for verification. Some directories will call or email to verify ownership. We'll generalize these steps so students can apply to various sites.

5. **Citation Management and Tools** – Managing dozens of listings can be time-consuming, so we introduce options. Some paid services (**LocalRank.so**, Yext, Moz Local, BrightLocal, etc.) can distribute and sync info across many directories. We explain the pros/cons: they save time but cost money, and some (like Yext) use a recurring model. For someone just starting, doing manual submission to the top 10-20 sites might be sufficient and a good learning



changes (address, phone), those listings all need updating to keep NAP consistent.

6. **Avoiding Duplicates and Errors** – As a final lesson, we warn about duplicate listings (e.g., two Yelp pages for the same business) which can dilute trust. We explain how to handle

finding a duplicate – usually by claiming it and merging or requesting removal. Also, be careful to enter info accurately the first time to avoid headaches. If a business has moved or changed name in the past, seek out those old citations and update or suppress them, so that only current info is indexed.

Implementation Steps:

- **Create a Master NAP Document:** Write down the business Name, Address, Phone exactly as you want it shown. Also include other standard info like website URL, business hours, description, and categories. Use this as your reference for all listings. Consistency is crucial.
- **List Target Directories:** List at least 10-15 citation sites to submit to. Start with big ones: **Yelp, Facebook, Apple Maps, Bing (done), Yellow Pages, Foursquare**, plus any specific to your industry or country. If you're not sure which ones are best, search "[Your City] business directory" or see where competitors are listed (often their site might show logos of directories or a quick search of their phone number can reveal their citations).
- **Submit/Update Listings:** One by one, go through your list. For each site: search for the business name/phone on that platform first to see if a listing exists. If yes, claim it or request to change incorrect info. If no, proceed to add the business. Fill in all fields each site allows (don't skip adding a logo or photos if they let you – a more complete listing might be more trusted). Use your master doc to copy name, address, etc. exactly. This process can be spread over several days if needed, as some listings take time.
- **Verify Where Required:** Some directories will send a verification email or phone call. Be looking for those (or inform the client to expect a verification call/pin). Complete

need follow-up.

- **Check for Consistency:** After creating the citations, do a quick audit: search Google for the business phone number or exact name and see what listings show up. Ensure those you created show the right info. If you spot any rogue or

duplicate listings (e.g., an unclaimed listing someone else made long ago), take steps to claim or suppress them.

- **Maintain Your Citations:** Going forward, whenever core business info changes (address, phone, hours), update your Google Business Profile first, **then update all your citations**. You might set a calendar reminder every 6-12 months to re-check major citations for accuracy. Consistent citations will reinforce your local SEO strength over time.

Milestone: *By the end of Module 8, the business will be listed (or updated) on all the major online directories and mapping services with consistent information.* This dramatically increases the business's online footprint and sends strong trust signals to search engines. You've essentially created a wide net of references that all point to the same NAP and website, which boosts your credibility. The milestone outcome is a **comprehensive citation profile** – one of the core pillars of local SEO. Clients will also love seeing their business across many platforms, providing additional ways for customers to find them (some people use Yelp or Apple Maps directly, for example).